



THE WEIGHT OF GREATNESS

For Ancy Sojan, breaking a **22-year-old** national record was never the destination. It was merely proof she belonged among the world's best.

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As a little girl growing up in Nattika, a small fishing village on the coast of the Arabian Sea in Kerala's Thrissur district, Ancy Sojan loved music and dance. It was her father, Sojan, an athletics nut, who insisted she take up sports. He had been a promising athlete himself but had eventually given up the sport and started plying an autorickshaw to earn a living.

Slowly, he passed on his passion for track and field to his daughter.

"I used to run the 100m, 400m and do the long jump but I didn't have the right guidance and support when I was young. I had to stop and start driving an auto to provide for my family. But I always loved sport and I managed to convince Ancy to try something that I loved. Luckily, she also fell in love with it," he tells *Sportstar*.

Sojan did more than just plant the seed of interest in sport in Ancy's mind. After enrolling her in athletics coaching, he would drive her to and from her practice sessions at the neighbourhood club in Nattika where she learned sprinting before focusing on the long jump.

"I always took her in the morning and evening for training. If she had some competition in neighbouring towns, I would drive her there and watch her compete. I enjoyed that. I'd often miss a lot of rides.

Some of the other auto drivers would say, 'Sojan, why are you doing all this? She's an auto driver's daughter. What do you think she will do?' But I always knew that Ancy would do something special," he remembers.

During the Inter-State Athletics Championships at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar, Ancy did just that. The 25-year-old leaped an eye-popping 6.88m to smash the Indian national record in the women's long jump, erasing Anju Bobby George's mark of 6.83m that had stood for 22 years.

Ancy was just three years old when Anju set her mark at the Athens Olympics. It had stood across several generations of

Leaping to the top: Ancy Sojan now has the best jump by an Indian woman which also places her seventh among the world's top this year. BISWARANJAN ROUT